The endangered axolotl



One victim of the urban sprawl of Mexico City has been the tiny axolotl, a pale-colored salamander that looks like a fish but is actually an amphibian, and is also known as the Mexican walking fish.

Capable of growing up to 1 ft (30 cm) long, the axolotl feeds on aquatic insects, small fish, and crustaceans, and has the ability to regenerate severed limbs—a quality that has made it an important subject of scientific research. The captive version is also a familiar pet in aquariums around the world. Historically, wild axolotl lived in the urban canals of the Aztec capital city in the 13th century, and in the network of lakes around the city that fed these canals. As Mexico City has expanded, these canals have been lost, and the wild axolotl has declined. In 2006, it was put on the list of critically endangered species, and in 2019 the International Union for Conservation of Nature estimated that the declining population comprised only 50–1,000 wild axolotls. However, work is ongoing in Mexico to restore the axolotls' freshwater habitat and save this amphibian.

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